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Gala Gunman's Manifesto Twists Christian Faith To Justify Attack

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MadMuscles

BY PNW STAFF APRIL 27, 2026

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A political gala like the White House Correspondents' Dinner is designed to be one of Washington's most controlled, symbolic environments--an annual collision of media, politics, and public power performed under tight security and ritualized civility. That is precisely why the events surrounding the shooting attempt tied to this setting have landed with such force.

The suspect-identified as Cole Tomas Allen-sent a manifesto to his family shortly before the attack, framing himself in disturbingly self-congratulatory terms as the "Friendly Federal Assassin." The document laid out a structured moral defense of his actions, anticipating objections and attempting to dismantle them point by point.

From R500 to R350,000
Lula Lona

This was not described as a spontaneous act of rage, but as something he believed he had intellectually justified in advance.

Among the most revealing sections is his engagement with his own "Christian" ethics after describing himself as a "Christian" and thanking his church: "Thank you to my family, both personal and church, for your love over these 31 years".

His very first objection question in the manifesto was to address the critical words of Jesus over turning the other cheek. He wrote:

Objection 1: As a Christian, you should turn the other cheek.

His rebuttal:

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He directly anticipates the objection that his actions violate Jesus' command to "turn the other cheek," and responds with a reinterpretation:

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He argues that such teaching applies only to personal suffering, not to witnessing the suffering of others. From there, he takes a further step--claiming that refusing violent intervention in the face of perceived injustice is not moral restraint, but moral complicity.

That single inversion is the hinge on which his entire justification turns.

Because once restraint is redefined as guilt, violence stops being an act of aggression and becomes, in his framing, an act of moral necessity.

The Collapse of the Moral Argument

At face value, this kind of reasoning can appear emotionally persuasive. It appeals to empathy: the suffering of others, the desire not to be passive in the face of injustice. But ethically, it breaks down at the exact point where private moral judgment is converted into permission for lethal force.

Christian ethics has wrestled with precisely this tension for centuries. The Sermon on the Mount--especially "turn the other cheek" (Matthew 5:39)--is not a call to ignore injustice. It is a rejection of retaliatory violence as a moral tool of the individual. It is aimed at breaking cycles where injury demands repayment in kind.

The shooter's argument effectively rewrites this teaching into its opposite: not "do not repay evil with evil," but "you are obligated to repay evil with violence on behalf of others."

That shift is not a minor interpretation difference--it is a full reversal of the ethical boundary.

Because once an individual claims authority to determine when violence is morally required, and against whom, there is no limiting principle left. Every complex political or social reality becomes reducible to a personal verdict of guilt.

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Christianity and the Question of Violence

Within Christian theology, this issue is not new. The tradition contains a long-standing tension between nonviolence and state justice, often framed through ideas like the "just war" theory developed by Augustine and later refined by Aquinas. Even in those frameworks, however, the authority to use force is never given to isolated individuals acting on personal conviction.

It is constrained by legitimacy, proportionality, and collective responsibility.

That distinction matters here. The alleged manifesto logic removes all of those constraints and replaces them with individual moral certainty. It assumes that personal perception of injustice is sufficient authority for violent action.

Christian ethics has historically treated that assumption as one of the most dangerous moral errors possible--not because injustice should be ignored, but because humans are not morally infallible judges of ultimate guilt.

Anti-Trump & Anti-Christian Posts

Allen makes clear his disdain for Trump and those in his administration in his Manifesto and has additional social media posts that make this clear. To date we have not seen specific anti-Christian posts released other than his clear confusion over what the Bible teaches but some reports are saying he has also written other anti-Christian material.

If true, reports of hostility toward Christians within the suspect's own rhetoric add another layer of contradiction. It reflects a psychological and ideological fragmentation that is increasingly common in radicalized identity systems: the adoption of a moral or religious vocabulary while rejecting its ethical center.

In Christian terms, this is not a subtle inconsistency. It is a direct collapse of coherence.

A belief system centered on love of neighbor, restraint of vengeance, and the prohibition of murder cannot simultaneously be used to justify indiscriminate killing of perceived enemies without fundamentally ceasing to function as that belief system.

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The reports surrounding the suspect's academic background and accomplishments have also fueled public shock. A highly educated individual, described in some accounts as exceptionally gifted, appears on the surface to embody rational development and intellectual achievement.

But this case highlights a hard truth: intelligence is not moral orientation.

In fact, intellectual capability without ethical grounding can intensify ideological conviction rather than restrain it. It can produce arguments that feel internally consistent while remaining morally inverted.

The ability to construct a justification does not guarantee that the justification is legitimate. It only guarantees that it is persuasive to the person who constructed it.

The Core Ethical Failure

At the center of the manifesto's reasoning is a single fatal assumption: that violence can be morally purified by intent.

Christian ethics rejects that premise.

Even when confronting injustice, it draws a line between witnessing suffering and becoming the executor of punishment. The moment that line is erased, the moral framework no longer distinguishes justice from vengeance--it only distinguishes preferred targets.

And history repeatedly shows what follows when that boundary disappears: violence expands faster than its justification.

Not because people stop caring about justice, but because they become convinced that their version of justice authorizes anything.

The most troubling aspect of this case, as reported, is not only the alleged act itself, but the attempt to transform it into moral reasoning.

Once violence is framed as obedience to conscience, and conscience is framed as self-authorized judgment over others, restraint is no longer seen as virtue. It is reclassified as betrayal.

Christian teaching, at its core, resists that transformation. It places limits on the individual not to diminish justice, but to prevent justice from becoming indistinguishable from revenge.

When that limit is removed, what remains is not moral clarity.

It is moral permission--without boundaries, without accountability, and without end.

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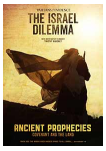

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